

Money Mistake: You Don't Have Time to Work and Study

THE FIX: GET THE RIGHT PART-TIME JOB

I'm going to sound like an old guy here, but when I was in school, kids worked. They didn't spend four to six hours a night on Facebook or playing video games. They worked in bars and restaurants near the campus and they lived with a pile of roommates, some sleeping on a cot in the hallway. That's just how it was. That's how you saved a buck. I monetized my shuffleboard hobby and made a killing playing three nights a week against other players in local pubs. Even if you have to lighten your study load and graduate in five rather than four years, it's better to do that than accumulate a massive debt.

Time is money as a student. Restaurant work also means tips, cash, and, nine times out of ten, it pays more than standing around in a store shilling jeans and shoes. Malls wind down at nine or ten o'clock at night, and so does a dinner shift in an average restaurant. But unlike the mall job, your restaurant job puts more cash in your pocket working the same number of hours. Some parents might have a problem with my encouraging kids to work in bars or restaurants. Get over it. If he or she is slinging beer for money, it means your precious child is not blowing money on beer and doesn't have enough time to drink it. But whether it's The Gap or Outback Steakhouse, kids: Get a job; just get one. Trust me, you have the time; you're just not allocating it properly.

I'll go even further. Even *after* you graduate and get a foothold in the nine-to-five work world, keep your part-time job at that restaurant or bar a couple of nights a week. Use that extra money to pay down your debt. Deal with balance and quality-of-life issues after you get out of debt. But while you're in debt, you're a hamster on a wheel. That also means having roommates to keep your rent low, watching movies at home (it's cheaper), and eating takeout instead of at fancy restaurants (or better yet, learning to cook—probably good for your love life, too). One of the big secrets to growing wealth is never changing your fundamental lifestyle as the money piles up. Don't